

7.b) Discuss Lewis Henry Morgan's evolutionary framework in anthropology. How did his theories reflect Western biases and assumptions about cultural superiority and progress? (15 marks)

Lewis Henry Morgan was an American Anthropologist famous for his work 'League of the Iroquois' & 'System of Consanguinity and Affinity in Human Family'.

Evolutionary framework proposed:

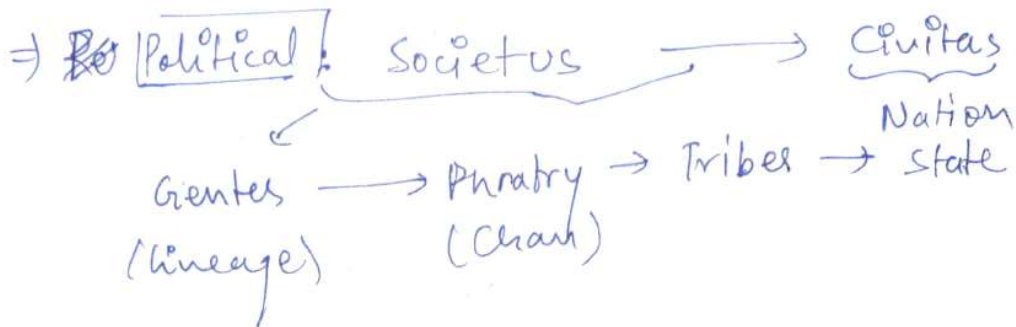
- He based his work on EB Tylor's 3 stage evolution for society
- He further sub-divided these into Upper, Middle and Lower individually based on material culture.

Savagery (Hunting and Gathering)
 Upper = Bow, arrow
 Middle = Fire
 Lower = Fruits, nuts
 eg Australia, Polynesia.

Barbarism (Agriculture)
 Upper = Iron
 Middle = Irrigation
 Lower = Pottery
 eg Iroquois

Civilization: Phonetics, alphabets, machine power
 eg Victorian England

→ He further applied these ~~to~~ evolutionary frameworks to different social institutions to explain their progress :-



⇒ Kinship : Kinship systems were studied by him based on kinship terminology.
classificatory descriptive

- Based on these terminology, he explained the cultures moved from classificatory to descriptive eg Hawaiian → Inuit → Iroquois
 Sudanese ← Crow ← Omaha

⇒ Marriage and Family → He described their evolution in 5 stages

Consanguine → Punaluan → Syndesmian → Patriarchal → Mono gamian

- Significance of works →
- ① 1st ethnographic field work among Iroquois
 - ② Evolutionary framework
 - ③ Father of kinship studies
 - ④ Inspired Karl Marx through idea of "Primitive Communism"

Theories by Morgan reflected Western bias & superiority

- ① Western idea of unilinear evolution
- ② Colonial view of stratification of culture with Civilization at top.
- ③ Idea of monogamous as highest marriage form shown Western view of marriage.
- ④ AL Kroeber: Kinship terminology are means of psychological expression ⇒ cannot be used to show how one culture is above another.
- ⑤ David Graeber in "Down of Everything" ~~"Evolution of Culture"~~
 - ↳ Against deterministic view of evolution
 - (eg. Poverty point culture of Louisiana) Did pottery & long-distance trade without Agriculture

In conclusion, Morgan's theory of change stands challenged. However he left indelible mark on anthropology.